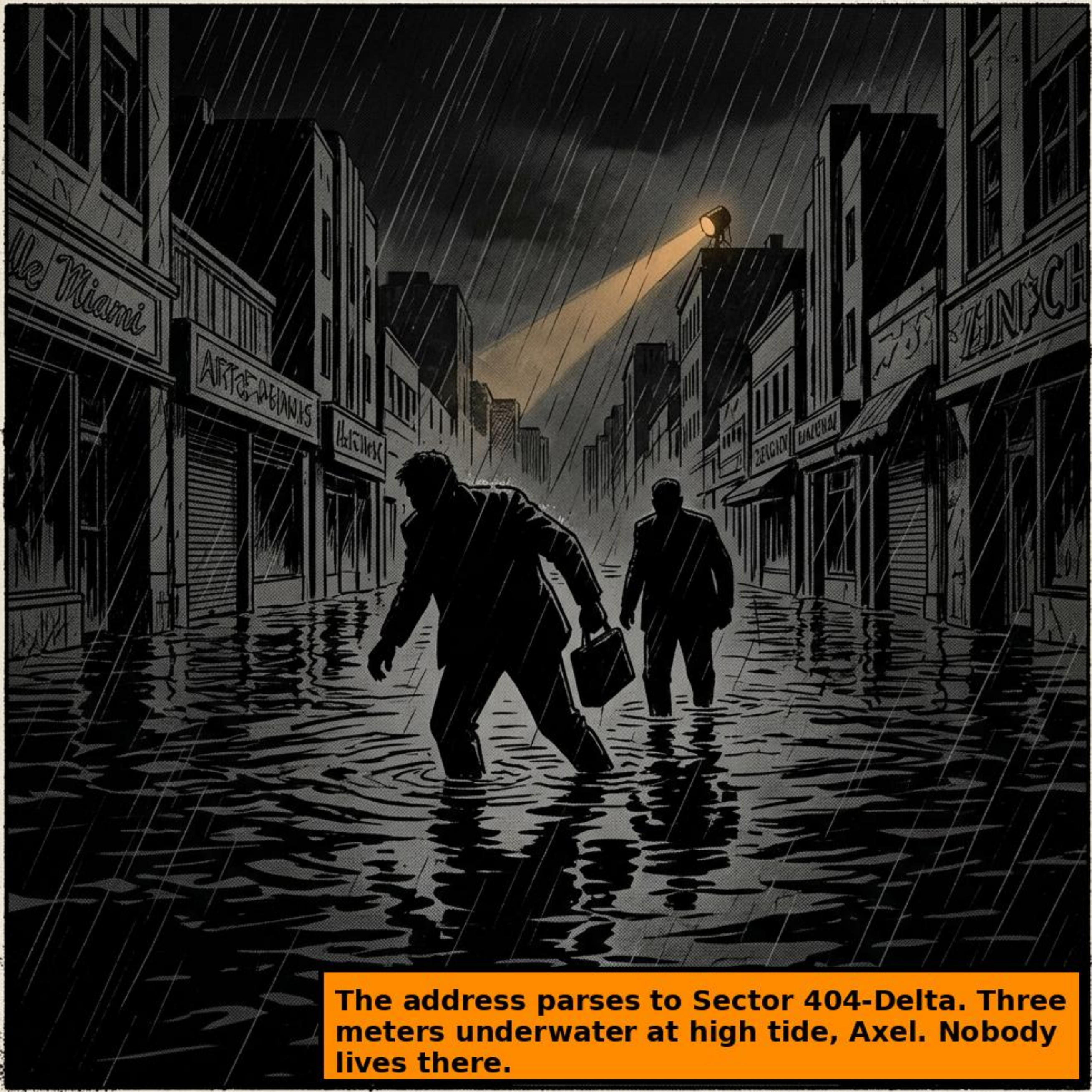


The second signal. Reya ran the printout. Not a corporate node. Not a Cartel relay. A single residential terminal in the Drowned District. Someone in the water has been reading the Grid-Tape for months.





The address parses to Sector 404-Delta. Three meters underwater at high tide, Axel. Nobody lives there.

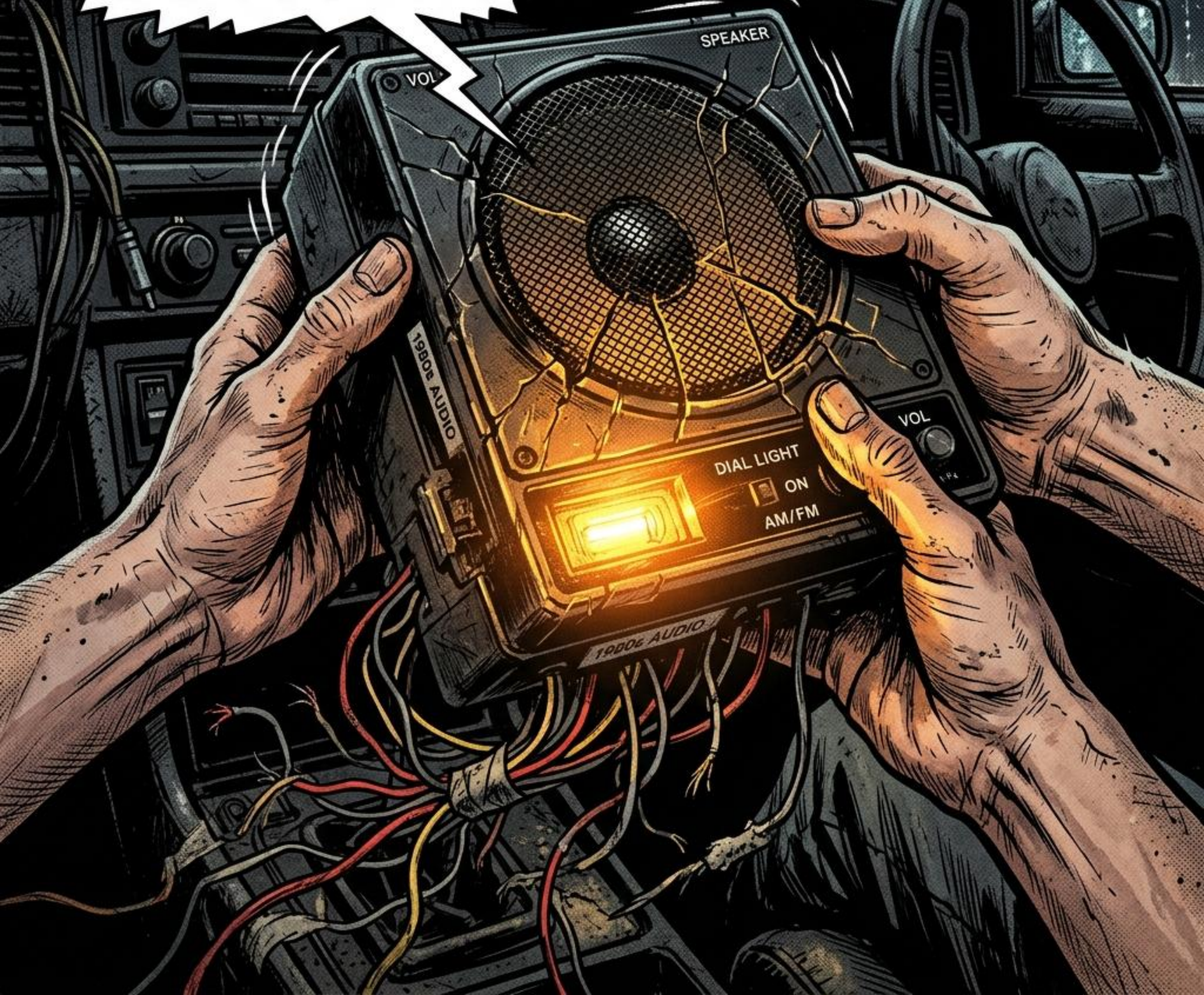
JULY 1987. NORTH MIAMI AVENUE.

Nobody they have on record.



...Cutter... Override Protocol... your
mother's archive... is scheduled for... full
Erasure... at 0600...

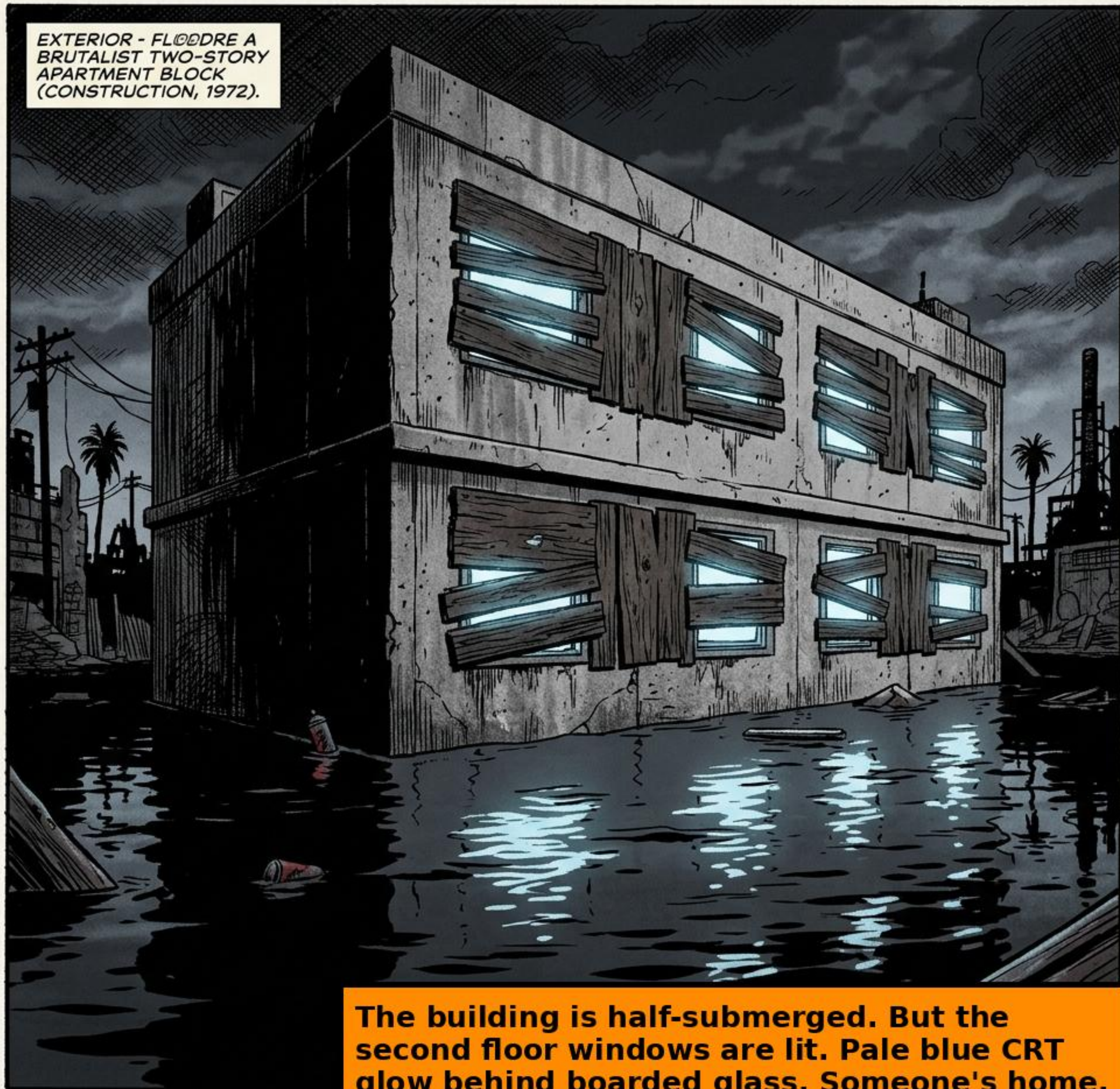
BEACH...**HISS**...MAYDAY...
KRRRSH...SHOTS...**CRACK**...





Axel. I know what you heard. Keep moving. You can't help her if you're standing in the open.

EXTERIOR - FLOODRE A
BRUTALIST TWO-STORY
APARTMENT BLOCK
(CONSTRUCTION, 1972).



The building is half-submerged. But the second floor windows are lit. Pale blue CRT glow behind boarded glass. Someone's home.

I've been reading the Tape's broadcast for two years. Every time Vance ran a Sector Format, I intercepted the bleed frequency. I have a record of everything they've deleted.



Can you pull her file from the Vanguard servers before 0600?



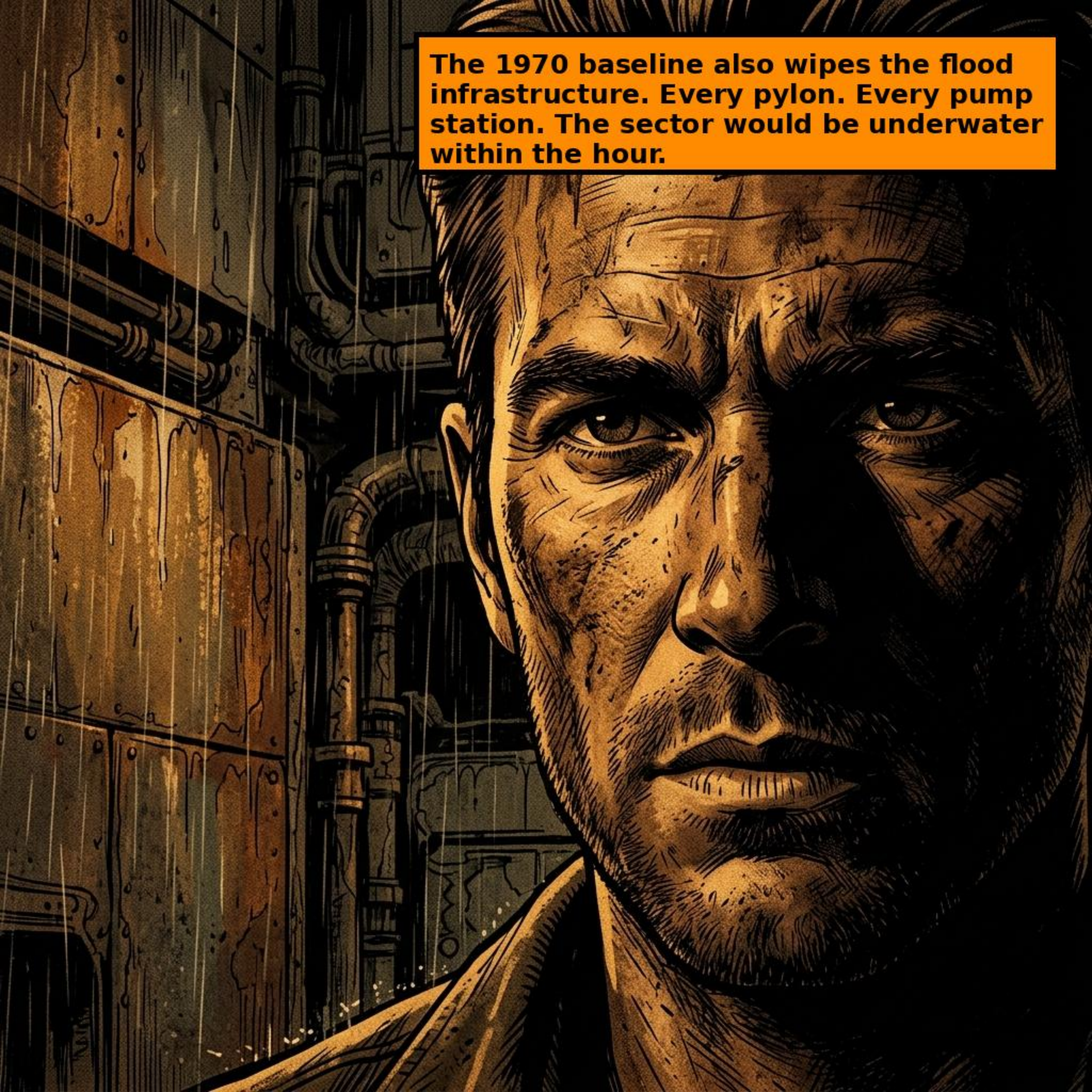


I can reach the server. But if I do, it triggers a locator pulse. Vance will have this building surrounded in eleven minutes.

If you play the Tape into the Freedom Tower terminal, it doesn't just reformat the city. It flushes every debt record. Every repossession order. Every foreclosure file. Gone.

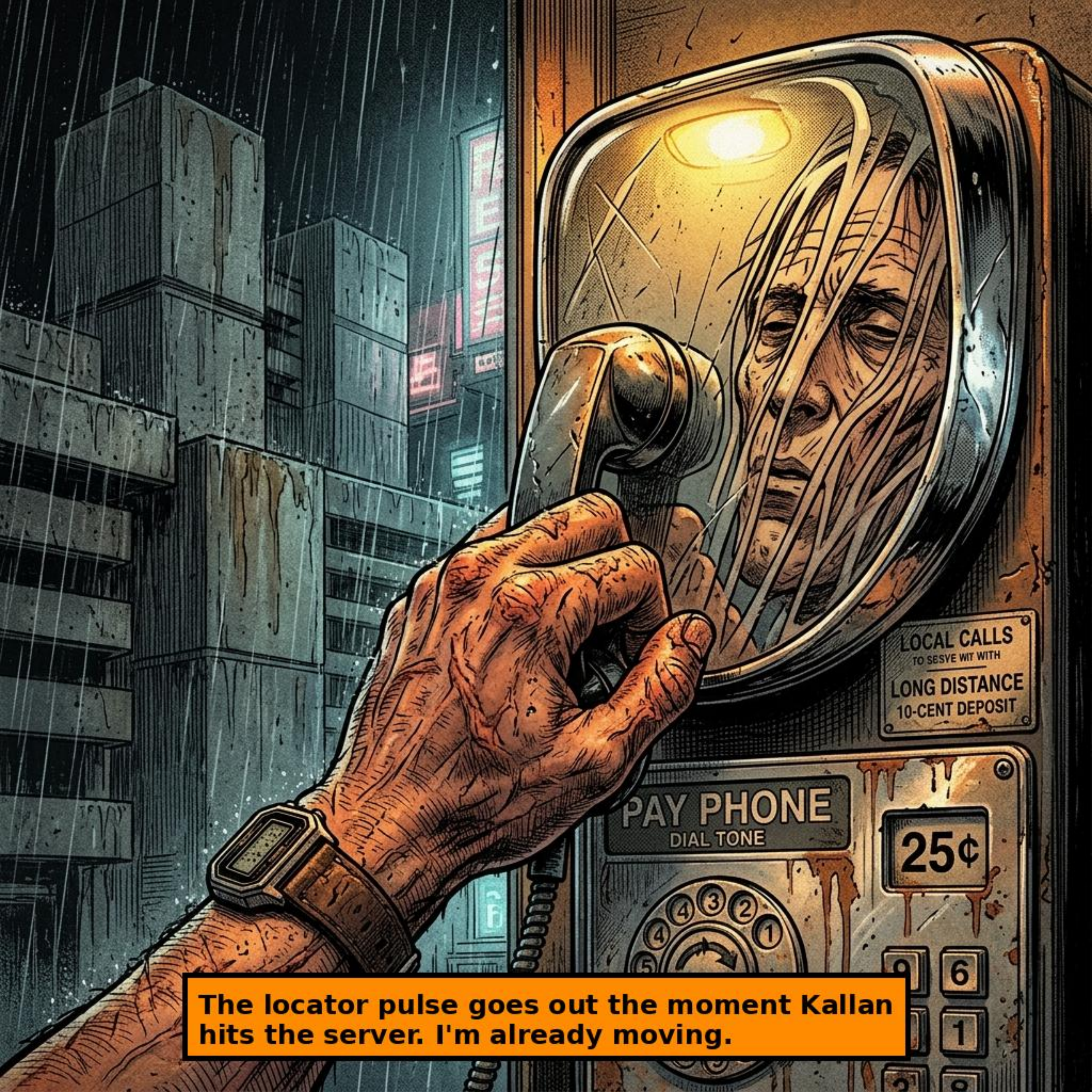


The 1970 baseline also wipes the flood infrastructure. Every pylon. Every pump station. The sector would be underwater within the hour.





Kallan. Pull my mother's archive. Buy me eleven minutes. Not the whole Grid. Not yet. Just her.



The locator pulse goes out the moment Kallan hits the server. I'm already moving.



Vance. I have the Tape. And I have a proposition. You're going to want to hear this in person. Eleven minutes. I intend to use every single one of them.